Gangadevi). Pampa's mother is one of the women, though she was not widowed in the battle, who walk into the fire at the beginning of the novel. The trauma results somehow (as with all Rushdie's novels, it requires of the reader not so much a suspension of disbelief as a willingness to submit before the power of the storyteller; it is, ironically, an act of faith) in the voice of the goddess Pampa, a variation of Parvati, emerging from the mouth of the nine-year-old.

It gave, the narrator notes mischievously, "the young girl the unique experience of being personally spoken to by a supernatural stranger speaking through her own mouth". Pampa ends up at the cave of Vidyasagar, an ascetic in his twenties, a scholar with "long curly locks flowing down his back all the way to his waist" who is committed to non-violence and "abstinence from the things of the flesh". Faced with Pampa though, Vidyasagar's abstinence is merely theoretical: "This was how men were, Pampa Kampana thought. A man philosophised about peace but in his treatment of the helpless girl sleeping in his cave his deeds were not in alignment with his philosophy."

It's an early lesson. One that is reiterated throughout the novel—we are hypocrites, we say one thing and do another. Our lives, our triumphs and failures, are measured in the distance between our stated principles and ideals and our actions. But humans and their great struggles wither. What remains are words, the words through which we impart the lessons of our defeat. ■

Shougat Dasgupta

BOOKS

PARADISE LOST

Tsering Yangzom Lama's debut novel tells the story of Tibetans, whose nation survives in exile

Tsering Yangzom Lama's debut novel *We Measure the Earth with Our Bodies* begins with a dedication to her parents and relations and "to every soul who has known, lost, and sought home". While that applies to most people in some measure, it is particularly, and poignantly, true of Tibetans, whose nation survives in exile, removed from a territory now controlled by the Chinese.

The novel opens in the early 1960s. An oracle leads half her village to Nepal across the mountains as the People's Liberation Army consolidates its grip over Tibet. It's a long, icy march with few possessions. Many die along the way, including the oracle and her husband, leaving their daughters, Lhamo and Tenkyi, to be raised by relatives. Their journey and their subsequent lives in refugee camps and settlements mirror the story of many Tibetans in exile today.

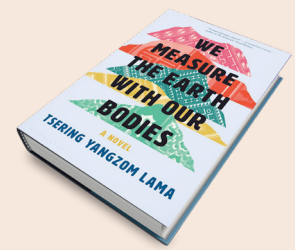
The dominant mood is one of fragmentation and displacement. Tibet used to be a theocracy, a nation built around its monasteries and relics. (A young Lhamo wonders why her people had "only monks and nuns, but not an army".) So, their uprooting in a sense is a dual one, from land as well as from the hallowed ground. The novel's story spans the years from 1960 to 2012, and is told by multiple narrators—Lhamo, her daughter Dolma, Tenkyi and a man named Samphel —at staggered points in time.

The novel captures refugee life marked by communities of circumstance—people who look out for those they find themselves with. At the same time, people are frighteningly easy to lose across multiple camps and countries. A love story that runs through the book is continually thwarted by missed connections. Some of their mother's oracular powers have rubbed off on Lhamo and Tenkyi, who occasionally go into a trance or see visions. It's part of the Tibetan tradition, but in the book's world, it seems as if a little extraordinary perception is almost necessary to hold things together.

The arc of the novel set in 2012 has a twenty-something Dolma living with her aunt in Toronto, a country behind whose welcome she finds "a national self-regard that insists on a mythic goodness". Here she sees (and shows us) some finely-observed aspects of a globalised Tibet: as a glamorous cause; as a subject for western academics who actually get to visit Tibet; as Little Tibet, which is "the camp built anew. A copy of a copy of home". And not least as represented by fetishised artefacts that magically find their way into museums. A small idol of a saint that appears wherever people need him pops up throughout the book, including at a collector's.

Lama's writing is deft without calling much attention to itself, and always in the present tense, as if inhabiting a constant precariousness. Lama manages to tell a few Tibetan stories against the backdrop of the larger story of Tibetan nationhood, which, she writes, "repeats and repeats, drowning out all of our other stories". ■

Srinath Perur



WE MEASURE THE EARTH WITH OUR BODIES
by Tsering Yangzom Lama
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THE NOVEL CAPTURES REFUGEE LIFE MARKED **BY COMMUNITIES OF CIRCUMSTANCE—PEOPLE WHO LOOK** OUT FOR THOSE THEY FIND THEMSELVES WITH